

Crypto Exchange Without Losses

A practical guide to exchanging crypto and money via exchange monitors

Author: Maxim Sementsul

RateScout project

Age rating: 18+

Important information (disclaimer)

This book is **for educational and informational purposes only**. It is **not**:

- individual investment, financial, tax or legal advice;
- an offer, solicitation or recommendation to buy, sell, exchange or hold any asset, including cryptocurrencies;
- a guarantee of any result, income or profit.

All decisions about handling cryptocurrencies and money you make **yourself and at your own risk**. Cryptocurrency operations carry the risk of full or partial loss of funds, technical risks, and the risk of fraud and price volatility.

The legal status of cryptocurrencies differs from country to country and changes over time. In some jurisdictions certain operations are restricted or prohibited; in others they are governed by special rules (for example, identification, taxation or licensing requirements). **The reader is solely responsible for ensuring that their actions comply with the laws of their country of residence and the place where the operation is performed.** The author and publisher accept no liability for the reader's breach of applicable law.

Any rates, fees, service names and figures mentioned are given for illustration and **may differ from current values**. Information is provided as of the time of writing and may become outdated.

Names of services, networks and products mentioned in this book are trademarks of their respective owners and are used for reference and descriptive purposes only; the book is not affiliated with them and does not represent their views.

The material is intended for readers **over the age of 18**.

If you need individual advice, consult a licensed professional (financial, tax or legal) in your jurisdiction.

About this book

The world of crypto exchange only seems complicated at the entrance. In reality, most beginner losses are not a "market crash" but simple, repeating mistakes: choosing a

bad rate, sending a coin on the wrong network, not checking the exchanger, believing an offer that is "too good".

This book is about **not losing money for no reason**. No hype, no promises of riches, no trading strategies. Just practice: how exchange works, how to read a rate, how to pick a reliable service, where fees hide, and how to tell an honest exchanger from a trap.

The book was prepared by the author as part of **RateScout** – an exchange-rate monitoring service. It is based on daily observation of the market: what beginners most often lose on, and what actually helps to avoid it. There is no advertising or links in the main part – knowledge first; practical resources and addresses are collected in the final section.

How to read: chapters go from simple to advanced. If you are a complete beginner, read in order. If you already know something, take the chapter you need – each is self-contained, and at the end there is a glossary and checklists.

Contents

1. What crypto exchange is and why you need an exchange monitor
 2. How to read a rate: spread, reserve, rating and reviews
 3. Networks and fees: TRC20, ERC20, BEP20, TON – where it is cheaper and why
 4. Stablecoins (USDT, USDC): why they are used in exchange and what a depeg is
 5. How to pick a reliable exchanger and avoid scammers
 6. AML address check: what it is and when it really matters
 7. Common beginner mistakes and how to avoid them
 8. Step by step: your first safe exchange
 9. Glossary and checklists
 10. Useful resources
-

Chapter 1. What crypto exchange is and why you need an exchange monitor

An exchange is not a trading platform

The first thing to separate in your head is that an **exchange (swap)** and a **trading exchange (a crypto exchange platform)** are different things, even though both let you "swap one thing for another".

A **trading platform** is a marketplace where users trade with each other: they place buy and sell orders, and the platform matches them. To swap anything you need to register, pass verification, fund your account, and understand the order book, order types and maker/taker fees. This is convenient for active trading but excessive for the simple task of "swap rubles for USDT and withdraw".

An **exchange office (exchanger)** solves one task: take one asset from you and give another at a stated rate. No order books, no orders – you see the rate, you give, you receive. It is closer to how a street currency exchange works, only online and with cryptocurrencies.

Exchangers have their own features: each has its own rate, its own **reserve** (how much it is ready to pay out), its own fees and its own reputation. And here is the beginner's main question: **how do you pick a profitable and reliable one out of hundreds of exchangers?** That is what a monitor is for.

What an exchange monitor is

A **monitor** is an aggregator service that collects the rates of many exchange offices for the direction you need in one place and shows them as a list, usually sorted by how favourable they are.

Imagine you want to swap USDT for rubles to a card. Manually it would look like this: open dozens of exchanger sites, find the right direction on each, compare the rate, check the reserve, read the reviews. An hour of work – and it is still easy to make a mistake.

A monitor does this for you in seconds: you choose the direction "USDT → rubles to a card" and see a table where the most favourable offers are on top, with each exchanger's rate, reserve and rating. Then you go to the chosen office and make the exchange on its site.

The key point: **the monitor itself does not exchange money.** It does not take your cryptocurrency and does not hold funds. It shows information and directs you to an exchanger. This matters both for safety (the monitor has nothing to steal from you) and for understanding responsibility: the quality and honesty of the deal are on the side of the exchange office you chose, while the monitor only helps you find it.

Why you need this

Three reasons a monitor saves money and nerves:

1. **The rate.** The rate difference between exchangers for the same direction can reach several percent. On a sum of 100,000 rubles that is thousands of rubles "out of thin air" – just for looking at a list instead of going to the first service you found.
2. **The reserve.** An exchanger may have a great rate but only 5,000 rubles in reserve – while you need to withdraw 200,000. The monitor shows the reserve in advance, and you do not waste time on an office that physically cannot pay out the amount you need.
3. **Reputation.** Good monitors show the rating and reviews of exchangers and remove those with mass complaints. This is the first (though not the only) filter against scammers.

What a typical exchange looks like

To tie it all together, here is the path of an ordinary person who wants to swap cryptocurrency:

1. **Define the direction.** What you swap and into what: for example, "USDT (TRC20 network) → rubles to a Sberbank card".
2. **Open the monitor** and select this direction.
3. **Look at the list** of exchangers sorted by rate. Pay attention not only to the top line but also to the reserve and rating (see Chapter 2).
4. **Pick an exchanger** and go to its site.
5. **Create an order:** enter the amount and your details (wallet address or card number).
6. **Make the transfer** following the exchanger's instructions.
7. **Receive the funds** and check that everything adds up.

It sounds simple – and with care it is. But at every step there are nuances that make beginners lose money: the wrong rate, the wrong network, an unverified exchanger, haste. The following chapters are devoted to these nuances.

Key takeaways

- An **exchange (swap)** is simpler than a trading platform: you swap an asset at a stated rate, without trading and orders.
- Each exchanger has its own **rate, reserve, fees and reputation** – choosing blindly is unprofitable and risky.
- A **monitor** collects exchangers' offers in one place and sorts them by how favourable they are; it does not exchange money and does not hold funds.
- A monitor saves on the **rate**, protects you via the **reserve**, and filters by **reputation**.
- Responsibility for the deal itself is on the chosen **exchanger**; the monitor helps you find it.

Chapter 2. How to read a rate: spread, reserve, rating and reviews

The list of exchangers in a monitor looks deceptively simple: a column of rates, "the best" on top. But the top line is not always the best choice. Let us see what to actually look at.

Rate and spread

The **rate** is how many units of one asset you get for a unit of another. For example, "USDT → rubles, rate 78" means you get 78 rubles for 1 USDT.

The **spread** is the difference between the buy rate and the sell rate. The exchanger earns exactly on it: it buys from you a little cheaper and sells a little dearer. The smaller the spread, the better for you. A monitor helps you see the spread indirectly – simply by comparing the rates of different offices for one direction: if most have 78 and one has 82, that is usually not "generosity" but a reason to look closer (see Chapter 5 on scammers).

Importantly, the rate is not the only number. An exchanger with a slightly worse rate but a large reserve, a high rating and no hidden fees is often more profitable than the "best by rate" one that has surprises at every step.

Reserve

The **reserve** is how much of the asset the exchanger is ready to give you right now. If you swap 300,000 rubles into USDT but the exchanger has a reserve of 50,000 rubles, the deal will not go through or will go through only partially.

Always check the reserve against your amount **before** creating an order. A good habit is to choose an office whose reserve is noticeably larger than your amount: it is both a safety margin and a sign that the exchanger works with serious volumes.

Rating and reviews

Monitors show exchangers' **rating** and number of reviews. The rating is accumulated reputation: how fast it pays out, whether it cheats, how it handles disputes.

How to read reviews wisely: - **Look at recent ones**, not only the overall score. An exchanger could have been good a year ago and "broke" recently. - **Look for specifics**. "They stole 10,000" with details matters more than a faceless "bad". - **Assess how the exchanger responds** to negativity: a live dialogue and a solution is a good sign; ignoring or aggression is a bad one. - **Do not chase zero complaints**. Large offices always have some unhappy clients; what matters is the ratio and how conflicts are resolved.

What to compare in the end

Before choosing, keep four parameters in mind, not one:

1. **Rate** – how favourable it is.
2. **Reserve** – whether it covers your amount.
3. **Rating/reviews** – whether it can be trusted.
4. **Fees and terms** – whether there are hidden charges (see Chapters 3 and 5).

Key takeaways

- The top line by rate is not automatically the best choice.
- The **spread** is what the exchanger earns on; compare the rates of several offices.
- Check the **reserve** before ordering – it should cover your amount with a margin.
- **Rating and recent reviews** matter more than the overall score; look at how conflicts are resolved.
- Decide by the whole picture: rate + reserve + reputation + terms.

Chapter 3. Networks and fees: TRC20, ERC20, BEP20, TON – where it is cheaper and why

One of the most painful and common beginner mistakes is losing money on the **network**. Let us figure out what it is and how not to overpay (and not to send a coin "into the void").

What a network is

The same cryptocurrency can exist on different **networks (blockchains)**. For example, USDT exists on **TRC20** (Tron), **ERC20** (Ethereum), **BEP20** (BNB Chain), **TON** and others. The coin is called the same – USDT – but the "roads" it travels on are different.

The key rule: **the sender and the receiver must use the same network**. If you send USDT on the TRC20 network to an address that expects USDT on the ERC20 network, the funds will most likely be **lost irreversibly**. Usually neither the exchanger nor the wallet can recover them.

Why fees differ

A **network fee** is paid for a transfer on the network (do not confuse it with the exchanger's fee) – it goes to miners/validators, not to the service. Its size depends heavily on the network:

- **TRC20 (Tron)** – usually a cheap fee, which is why it is the most popular option for USDT in the CIS.
- **ERC20 (Ethereum)** – historically expensive; the fee can "eat" a noticeable part of a small amount; but it is the most widespread and supported everywhere.
- **BEP20 (BNB Chain)** – cheap, but not supported by all services.
- **TON** – fast and cheap, gaining popularity.

For small amounts the fee difference is critical: sending 20 USDT via ERC20 can be unprofitable if the network fee is comparable to the amount. For the same 20 USDT, TRC20 or TON makes more sense.

How not to make a network mistake

1. **Verify the network on both sides.** The exchanger states which network it expects the coin on; your wallet states which one it sends on. They must match exactly.
2. **Do not rely on the coin name alone.** "USDT" without a stated network is incomplete information.
3. **Test with a small amount first** on your first exchange with a new exchanger or to a new address (more on this in Chapter 8).
4. **Include the fee in your profit calculation.** Sometimes the rate is better, but an expensive network eats the difference.

Key takeaways

- One coin lives on **different networks** (TRC20/ERC20/BEP20/TON) – these are different "roads".
 - ■ **The sender's and receiver's networks must match**, otherwise the funds are lost irreversibly.
 - The **network fee** goes to the network, not the exchanger; TRC20/TON are usually cheap, ERC20 is expensive.
 - For small amounts choose a cheap network; always include the fee in your profit calculation.
-

Chapter 4. Stablecoins (USDT, USDC): why they are used in exchange and what a depeg is

If you have ever exchanged cryptocurrency, you have almost certainly come across stablecoins. Let us see what they are and why they are so convenient – and where their weak spot is.

What a stablecoin is

A **stablecoin** is a cryptocurrency pegged to the value of a regular currency, most often the US dollar. The idea: $1 \text{ USDT} \approx 1 \text{ dollar}$, $1 \text{ USDC} \approx 1 \text{ dollar}$. Unlike bitcoin, whose price jumps around, a stablecoin is designed as a "digital dollar" with a stable price.

That is exactly why stablecoins became the "workhorse" of exchange: they are convenient to temporarily hold funds in, to settle with, and almost all exchange directions pass through them nicely ("rubles $\rightarrow$ USDT $\rightarrow$ another crypto").

Why they are used in exchange

- **An intermediate asset.** It is often more profitable to swap not directly "rubles $\rightarrow$ a rare coin" but through USDT: "rubles $\rightarrow$ USDT $\rightarrow$ the coin". More exchangers, a better rate, a larger reserve.
- **A pause without volatility.** If you want to "go to cash" but not into rubles, a stablecoin lets you wait it out without catching a price jump.
- **Universality.** USDT/USDC are accepted almost everywhere and on almost all networks.

What a depeg is and why it is a risk

A **depeg** is a situation where a stablecoin loses its peg and its price deviates from the dollar: for example, 1 USDT is worth not 1.00 but 0.95 dollars.

A depeg happens rarely, but it is real: during issuer problems, market panic or technical failures. Even a small deviation matters, because stablecoins are used as a "safe haven" – and that is exactly when they can let you down.

How to view depeg risk sensibly: - **Look at the stablecoin's price at the moment.** If 1 USDT is noticeably below 1 dollar, that is a signal to check the news, not to rush a large operation. - **Do not hold everything in one stablecoin for long** without need. - **Large, long-running stablecoins** are usually more stable – but "too stable" guarantees do not exist in crypto.

Key takeaways

- A **stablecoin** is pegged to the dollar (USDT, USDC $\approx 1 \text{ \$}$) – a "digital dollar" without sharp jumps.

- In exchange it is a convenient **intermediate asset**: more directions with a better rate pass through USDT.
 - A **depeg** is a rare but real deviation from the dollar peg; watch the stablecoin's price at the moment.
 - A stablecoin's stability is not an absolute guarantee; large and old ones are usually more reliable.
-

Chapter 5. How to pick a reliable exchanger and avoid scammers

This is perhaps the most important chapter. Losing on a bad rate is annoying; falling for a scammer is genuinely painful. Let us see how to tell an honest exchanger from a trap.

Red flags: when to be wary

- **A rate that is "too good".** If everyone has 78 and one has 84, that is usually bait, not a gift. An abnormally favourable rate is a reason to check, not to rejoice.
- **No or almost no reviews / rating.** A freshly created office with no history is an increased risk.
- **Pressure and haste.** "The rate is only now", "transfer faster or it will cancel" – a classic trick so you do not have time to think.
- **They ask you to "pay extra to receive".** You have transferred – and you are told "pay a fee/insurance/tax, otherwise we will not release it". A real exchanger takes its fee from the rate and does not demand extra payments after the transfer. This is almost always fraud.
- **Communication only in a messenger,** not through a site with an order and history.
- **They demand extra data** (passwords, wallet access, codes) – a legitimate exchange does not need this.

What reduces risk

1. **Choose through a monitor with ratings,** not by a link from private messages or ads.
2. **Read recent reviews** specifically for that office (Chapter 2).
3. **Start small.** Your first exchange with a new service should be a small amount (Chapter 8).
4. **Check the reserve and terms** before transferring.
5. **Do not rush.** If you are being rushed, that itself is a reason to stop.

Sound logic

Scammers play on two emotions: **greed** ("what a favourable rate!") and **fear** ("hurry or it will be gone"). If an offer triggers a strong emotion, take a pause. A calm, "boring" exchange at a normal rate with a verified office – that is the right exchange.

Key takeaways

- An abnormally **favourable rate** is more often bait than a gift.
- ■ A demand to **pay extra after the transfer** to "receive" is almost always fraud.

- Dangerous signs: haste, pressure, no history/reviews, communication only in a messenger, requests for extra data.
 - Protection: a monitor with ratings, recent reviews, a small-amount test, no haste.
-

Chapter 6. AML address check: what it is and when it really matters

The word "AML" sounds complicated, but the idea is simple. Let us see what it is, why it exists and when it is worth spending time on.

What AML is

AML (Anti-Money Laundering) is a set of checks that help understand whether a crypto address or transaction is linked to "dirty" money: fraud, stolen funds, sanctions lists, the darknet.

For an ordinary person, an AML address check answers the question: **"am I at risk accepting this cryptocurrency or sending it to this address?"** If a coin has a "bad history", it may be frozen on the receiving service's side, and you will have to explain yourself.

When it really matters

Not every operation requires a deep check. But there are cases where it is justified:

- **Before accepting a large amount** from a little-known counterparty.
- **Before exchanging crypto for cash or a bank** – sensitivity to the "cleanliness" of funds is higher here.
- **If the counterparty is unknown** and you are not sure about the origin of the coins.

For small everyday operations between trusted parties, a deep AML score is usually excessive – common sense and a basic check are enough.

What can and cannot be checked

Basically you can check against **official sanctions lists** (for example, public OFAC lists) and look at basic on-chain data of the address. This cuts off the most obvious problems.

A full AML score (analysis of the address's links to mixers, scams, the darknet) is performed by specialized blockchain-analysis services – usually for a fee. It is important to understand the difference: a basic check $\neq$ a full score. A basic one is a quick filter of "is the address on a sanctions list"; a full one is a deep analysis of history.

Key takeaways

- An **AML check** answers: is the address/coin linked to "dirty" money.
- "Dirty" coins can be **frozen** on the receiver's side – hence the risk.
- A check especially matters **before a large amount** and **before withdrawal to cash/a bank**, with an unknown counterparty.

- A **basic** check (sanctions lists, on-chain data) $\neq$ a **full** AML score (specialized services, paid).
-

Chapter 7. Common beginner mistakes and how to avoid them

Let us gather the typical pitfalls in one place – so you do not step on them. Much of this was mentioned in previous chapters; here is a short "memory list".

1. **The wrong network.** Sent USDT on TRC20 to an ERC20 address – lost it. **Fix:** always verify the network on both sides (Chapter 3).
2. **Chasing the best rate at any cost.** An abnormal rate is often bait. **Fix:** look at the whole picture (rate + reserve + rating), do not rush (Chapters 2, 5).
3. **Exchanging via a link from private messages or ads.** **Fix:** choose through a monitor with ratings (Chapter 5).
4. **A large amount on your very first exchange** with a new service. **Fix:** test with a small amount first (Chapter 8).
5. **An error in the address/details.** One wrong character and the money is gone. **Fix:** copy the address, do not type it by hand; check the first and last characters; use a QR code where appropriate.
6. **Ignoring the reserve.** The order does not go through or goes through partially. **Fix:** check the reserve against the amount in advance (Chapter 2).
7. **Paying extra "to receive".** **Fix:** never pay extra after a transfer to "unlock" it – that is fraud (Chapter 5).
8. **Haste under pressure.** **Fix:** if you are being rushed, stop; a normal exchange will wait a minute.
9. **Holding everything in one place / one stablecoin for long.** **Fix:** do not keep large amounts "for later" without need; remember the depeg (Chapter 4).
10. **No record of the operation.** **Fix:** save the order number, screenshots, the transaction hash – it will help in a dispute.

Key takeaways

- Most beginner losses are not "the market" but simple mistakes: the network, haste, carelessness, trusting the "favourable" and the "urgent".
- Every mistake is cured by one habit: **check and do not rush.**

Chapter 8. Step by step: your first safe exchange

Let us put it all together into a clear checklist. Go through it the first time – and after that it will become a habit.

Step by step

1. **Define the direction.** Precisely: what, into what and **on which network**. Example: "USDT (TRC20) → rubles to a card".
2. **Open the monitor** and select this direction.
3. **Compare the offices** by rate, reserve and rating (Chapter 2). Do not grab the top line blindly.
4. **Check the terms** of the chosen exchanger: minimum/maximum amount, fees, requirements.
5. **Do a small-amount test** if the exchanger is new to you or the address is new. A small loss on the fee is cheaper than losing the whole amount to a mistake.
6. **Create an order:** enter the amount and details. **Copy** the address/details, do not type them by hand. Verify the network.
7. **Check again** before sending: the network, the address (first and last characters), the amount.
8. **Send the transfer** following the exchanger's instructions.
9. **Save** the order number, the transaction hash, screenshots.
10. **Wait for the credit** and check that you received what was expected. If something is wrong, write to the exchanger's support with the order number.

Mini-rules for life

- **Do not rush.** Haste is the main ally of mistakes and scammers.
- **A small-amount test** is cheap insurance.
- **Verify the network** every time.
- **Record** your operations.

Key takeaways

- A safe exchange is a discipline of ten simple steps, not luck.
- Key safeguards: **comparison via a monitor, a small-amount test, checking the network and address, recording the operation.**

Chapter 9. Glossary and checklists

Short glossary

- **Exchanger (exchange office)** – a service that swaps one asset for another at its own rate.
- **Monitor** – an aggregator that collects exchangers' rates in one place.
- **Rate** – how much you get per unit of an asset.
- **Spread** – the difference between the buy and sell rate; the exchanger's earnings.
- **Reserve** – how much of the asset the exchanger is ready to pay out now.
- **Network (blockchain)** – the "road" a coin travels on (TRC20, ERC20, BEP20, TON...).
- **Network fee** – the payment for a transfer; it goes to the network, not the exchanger.
- **Stablecoin** – a cryptocurrency pegged to the dollar (USDT, USDC).
- **Depeg** – a stablecoin's deviation from its dollar peg.
- **AML** – a check for a link between an address/coin and "dirty" money.
- **Transaction hash** – a unique identifier of a transfer on the network.

Pre-exchange checklist

- Direction and **network** defined precisely.
- Office chosen via a monitor by **rate + reserve + rating**.
- **Reserve** covers the amount with a margin.
- **Recent reviews** for the office read.
- For a new service/address – a **small-amount test**.
- Address/details **copied**, network verified, amount checked.
- No **haste** and no demands to "pay extra to receive".
- **Order number and hash** saved.

"Red flags" checklist

- The rate is abnormally favourable.
- No history/reviews.
- They pressure you with urgency.
- They ask for extra payment after the transfer.
- Communication only in a messenger.
- They ask for passwords/access/codes.

If any of the "red flags" is checked – stop and re-verify.

Chapter 10. Useful resources

This section contains practical tools and addresses. Everything related to external resources and contacts is deliberately gathered here: the main part of the book is free of advertising and links.

The tool this book is built on

The book was prepared by the author as part of **RateScout** – an exchange-rate monitoring service. RateScout collects exchange offices' rates across hundreds of directions, shows the reserve and rating, helps you choose a profitable and reliable exchange, and provides a basic AML check of a crypto address.

Current rates and tools are available on the project's website:

RateScout – ratescout.ru

About the author

Maxim Sementsul is the author of the RateScout project, dedicated to monitoring cryptocurrency and money exchange rates. He has watched the exchange market for years and shares practical knowledge that helps to exchange assets profitably and safely.

In closing

Cryptocurrency rewards knowledge and punishes haste. If you remember three things from this whole book, let them be: **verify the network, do not rush, test with a small amount**. That is enough not to be among those who "lost for no reason".

Good and calm exchanges.

© Maxim Sementsul. This book is educational and is not financial, investment, tax or legal advice. 18+. The legal status of cryptocurrencies differs by country; the reader is responsible for complying with the laws of their jurisdiction.